

D677

Elementary Literacy Curriculum

Armored Drill

8 concepts · 12 items · 4 transfer items

What this is. Every concept in this course's public description, re-asked with more disguise than a practice test uses. Each stem carries facts that do not decide it. Every wrong answer is a named trap.

Source. Scope from the course's public description in the WGU Institutional Catalog (September 2026); items written from the field's standard body of knowledge. No WGU assessment item, course material or proprietary content is used or reproduced. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Western Governors University.

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How to run it

Paper first. Pencil. One pass, no notes, a timer if you want the pressure.

1. **Before you read the options**, fill the strip under the item: the target word (what is actually being asked), and the one fact in the stem that decides it.
2. **Principle before arithmetic**. Name the rule, then compute.
3. **Camouflage**. Most of every stem does not matter. Ask: which single fact decides this?
4. **Inverse pairs are the bait**. If two options are opposites, one of them is the trap built for you.
5. **Mark sure, unsure or guess** honestly. Sure-and-wrong is the most valuable miss on the page — it is a wrong mental model.
6. **Absolutes** (always, never, guarantee) are usually wrong. And recognizing an answer is not the same as owning it.
7. Items with a **heavy black bar** on the left are **transfer items**: the same principle, reversed or solved for a different variable.
8. Stop at the STOP page. Then grade, fill the triage grid, and tally the traps you fell for. The biggest tally is what you drill next.

The strip, filled in, looks like this:

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	_____	

Items

1.

A second grader who loves dinosaurs and has a large home library retells read-aloud stories in rich detail and uses advanced vocabulary. When reading on his own, he cannot sound out simple words such as “trip” or “stamp.” Under the Simple View of Reading, what limits his reading comprehension?

- A.** His reading interests — he should read only dinosaur books.
- B.** Decoding — comprehension is the product of both parts, so weak decoding caps it.
- C.** Nothing — strong oral language makes up for weak decoding.
- D.** Language comprehension — he needs more vocabulary work.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

2. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

On a 0–1 scale, a student’s decoding is 0.9 and language comprehension is 0.5. Using the Simple View formula, what is the predicted reading comprehension?

- A.** 0.7
- B.** 0.9
- C.** 1.4
- D.** 0.45

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

3.

A fourth-grade teacher in a school that just switched to a new schedule notices a student reads words quickly and accurately but struggles to understand a passage about how beavers build dams because she has never seen a beaver or a river. Which Reading Rope strand is weak?

- A.** Background knowledge, a language-comprehension strand.
- B.** Sight recognition, a word-recognition strand.
- C.** Decoding, because she cannot understand the words.
- D.** Phonological awareness.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

4.

A kindergarten teacher with a new carpet and colorful name tags leads this activity with no letters shown: “Say ‘mat.’ Now change /m/ to /s/. What word do you have?” What kind of activity is this?

- A. Vocabulary instruction.
- B. Phonemic awareness — manipulating individual sounds orally.
- C. Phonics — linking letters to sounds.
- D. Fluency practice, because it is done quickly.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

5. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A teacher wants a phonics activity, not a phonemic awareness activity. Which one fits?

- A. Students clap the syllables in “butterfly.”
- B. Students listen to a story and retell it.
- C. Students say the first sound in “fish.”
- D. Students build “ship” with letter tiles, saying each sound as they place s-h together and then i and p.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

6.

A first grader in a busy classroom with 24 students spells “jump” as JP and reads “jump” as “jam,” using the first and last letters. Her older sister is in fifth grade. Which of Ehri’s phases best fits?

- A. Partial alphabetic.
- B. Full alphabetic.
- C. Consolidated alphabetic.
- D. Pre-alphabetic.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

7.

Third graders, using a new set of phonics workbooks, divide “robot” as ro-bot. The teacher asks what sound the o in the first syllable makes. The class has 22 students. What is the answer?

- A. Short o, because “ro” is a closed syllable.
- B. Long o, because “ro” is an open syllable.
- C. Silent, because vowels are always silent at the end of a syllable.
- D. Short o, like the o in “bot.”

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

8. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Which word begins with a closed syllable?

- A. cake
- B. hotel (ho-tel)
- C. napkin (nap-kin)
- D. music (mu-sic)

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

9.

A fifth-grade teacher who coaches the chess club writes “unhappiness” on the board during a word study lesson on a rainy Monday. How many morphemes does the word have?

- A. 3
- B. 11
- C. 4
- D. 2

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

10.

A third grader who is new to the school reads a passage at 130 words per minute with 98% accuracy, well above the benchmark. She reads in a flat voice, ignores periods, and cannot say what happened. Her family recently moved from another state. What is the best judgment about her fluency?

- A.** Her reading reflects adjustment to the move.
- B.** She needs phonics intervention.
- C.** Not yet fluent — accuracy and rate are strong but prosody is weak, and comprehension is suffering.
- D.** Fully fluent, because her rate is above benchmark.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

11. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A teacher wants to build prosody, not just speed. Which practice fits best?

- A.** Flash cards of isolated sight words.
- B.** Timed one-minute readings with a goal to beat the last score.
- C.** Silent independent reading only.
- D.** The teacher models a passage with expression, then students echo-read and rehearse it for a reader's theater.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

12.

A first-grade team is choosing between two beautifully illustrated book sets that are both on sale this month. Set A uses repeating sentences with picture support and tells children to “look at the picture and think what makes sense.” Set B uses words built from the letter-sound patterns already taught. Which choice fits the science of reading for beginning readers?

- A.** Set A, because picture cues help children figure out words.
- B.** Neither — beginners should read only trade books.
- C.** Set B, because decodable text lets students practice the phonics they were taught.
- D.** Either, since both are on sale and well illustrated.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

STOP

Answers and dissection follow. Finish every item and every strip first.

Key and dissection

Struck-through text is the camouflage: facts that do not decide the item.

1. Answer B Concept 1

A second grader ~~who loves dinosaurs and has a large home library~~ retells read-aloud stories in rich detail and uses advanced vocabulary. When reading on his own, he cannot sound out simple words such as “trip” or “stamp.” Under the Simple View of Reading, what limits his reading comprehension?

Target word: which component limits comprehension **Decides:** Language comprehension is strong; decoding is weak.

A	Camouflage	Keys on interest; topic does not fix decoding.
B	Correct	Strong listening comprehension cannot show up in reading until he can decode the words.
C	Adjacent category	Treats the parts as additive; the model multiplies them.
D	Inverted operation	Reverses the profile; his vocabulary and retells are strengths.

2. Answer D Concept 1 • transfer

On a 0–1 scale, a student’s decoding is 0.9 and language comprehension is 0.5. Using the Simple View formula, what is the predicted reading comprehension?

Target word: compute RC **Decides:** $RC = D \times LC$.

A	Adjacent category	Averages the parts; the model multiplies.
B	Wrong stem number	The decoding score alone.
C	Inverted operation	Adds instead of multiplying.
D	Correct	$0.9 \times 0.5 = 0.45$.

3. Answer A Concept 2

A fourth-grade teacher ~~in a school that just switched to a new schedule~~ notices a student reads words quickly and accurately but struggles to understand a passage about how beavers build dams because she has never seen a beaver or a river. Which Reading Rope strand is weak?

Target word: which strand **Decides:** She lacks knowledge of the topic — a language-comprehension strand.

A	Correct	Knowledge of the world is part of the strategic, language-comprehension side of the rope.
B	Confusion set	Her word reading is quick and accurate.
C	Adjacent category	She can read the words; she lacks the ideas behind them.
D	Dropped element	Drops the fact that word reading is already fluent.

4. Answer B Concept 3

A kindergarten teacher ~~with a new carpet and colorful name tags~~ leads this activity with no letters shown: “Say ‘mat.’ Now change /m/ to /s/. What word do you have?” What kind of activity is this?

Target word: classify the activity **Decides:** No print; sounds are manipulated orally.

A	Adjacent category	Word meanings are not the focus.
B	Correct	Substituting phonemes without print is phonemic awareness.
C	Confusion set	Phonics requires print; none is shown.
D	Absolute language	Speed does not define fluency, and no connected text is read.

5. Answer D Concept 3 • transfer

A teacher wants a phonics activity, not a phonemic awareness activity. Which one fits?

Target word: choose the phonics task — reverse of classifying the PA task **Decides:** Phonics links sounds to letters in print.

A	Inverted operation	Oral syllable work — phonological awareness.
B	Adjacent category	Listening comprehension.
C	Confusion set	Isolating a phoneme orally is phonemic awareness.
D	Correct	Maps sounds to letters, including the digraph sh.

6. Answer A Concept 4

A first grader ~~in a busy classroom with 24 students~~ spells “jump” as JP and reads “jump” as “jam,” using the first and last letters. ~~Her older sister is in fifth grade.~~ Which of Ehri’s phases best fits?

Target word: which phase **Decides:** Uses some letter-sound links, usually first and last.

A	Correct	Some letter-sound connections, typically the first and last sounds.
B	Inverted operation	Would map every sound, spelling “jump” as JUMP or JUP.
C	Confusion set	Uses chunks like -ump and syllables — well beyond this.
D	Adjacent category	Pre-alphabetic readers use visual cues like logos, not letter sounds.

7. Answer B Concept 5

Third graders, ~~using a new set of phonics workbooks~~, divide “robot” as ro-bot. The teacher asks what sound the o in the first syllable makes. ~~The class has 22 students.~~ What is the answer?

Target word: vowel sound in the first syllable **Decides:** “ro” ends in a vowel — an open syllable.

A	Confusion set	A closed syllable ends in a consonant; “ro” does not.
B	Correct	An open syllable ends in a vowel, which is usually long.
C	Absolute language	Silent e is a different pattern; this o is pronounced.
D	Adjacent category	That is the second, closed syllable.

8. Answer C Concept 5 • transfer

Which word begins with a closed syllable?

Target word: find the closed syllable **Decides:** Closed = ends in a consonant, short vowel.

A	Adjacent category	Vowel-consonant-e — long a.
B	Confusion set	“ho” is open — long o.
C	Correct	“nap” ends in a consonant; short a.
D	Inverted operation	“mu” is open — long u.

9. Answer A Concept 6

A fifth-grade teacher ~~who coaches the chess club~~ writes “unhappiness” on the board during a word study lesson ~~on a rainy Monday~~. How many morphemes does the word have?

Target word: count morphemes **Decides:** un + happy + ness.

A	Correct	Prefix un-, base happy (spelled happi-), suffix -ness.
B	Wrong stem number	Counts letters, not meaning units.
C	Confusion set	Counts syllables (un-hap-pi-ness); “happy” is one morpheme even though it has two syllables.
D	Dropped element	Drops one affix — often the prefix.

10. Answer C Concept 7

A third grader ~~who is new to the school~~ reads a passage at 130 words per minute with 98% accuracy, well above the benchmark. She reads in a flat voice, ignores periods, and cannot say what happened. ~~Her family recently moved from another state.~~ What is the best judgment about her fluency?

Target word: judge fluency **Decides:** Prosody is missing and comprehension suffers.

A	Camouflage	Keys on the move; the reading profile itself shows the need.
B	Adjacent category	98% accuracy shows decoding is secure.
C	Correct	Fluency includes prosody and should support meaning.
D	Dropped element	Drops prosody; speed alone is not fluency.

11. Answer D Concept 7 • transfer

A teacher wants to build prosody, not just speed. Which practice fits best?

Target word: choose the prosody practice **Decides:** Prosody is expression, phrasing, and attention to punctuation.

A	Adjacent category	Builds word automaticity, not phrasing in connected text.
B	Inverted operation	Targets rate; can train fast, flat reading.
C	Dropped element	Drops the oral modeling and feedback prosody needs.
D	Correct	Modeling and repeated, purposeful reading build phrasing and expression.

12. Answer C Concept 8

A first-grade team is choosing between two ~~beautifully illustrated~~ book sets ~~that are both on sale this month~~. Set A uses repeating sentences with picture support and tells children to “look at the picture and think what makes sense.” Set B uses words built from the letter-sound patterns already taught. Which choice fits the science of reading for beginning readers?

Target word: resource choice **Decides:** Beginners need text they can decode with taught patterns.

A	Inverted operation	Trains guessing from pictures (three-cueing) instead of decoding.
B	Absolute language	Trade books matter for read-alouds, but beginners need decodable practice.
C	Correct	Aligns text with instruction and reinforces sounding out.
D	Camouflage	Price and art do not decide instructional fit.

Triage grid

Write each item number in the box it belongs to.

	Right	Wrong
Sure	Owled.	Concept inversion — top priority. A wrong mental model; it survives rewording.
Unsure / guess	Recognition, not mastery. Re-drill with the transfer.	Not learned yet.

Trap tally

For every miss, find the letter you chose in the key and tally its trap. The biggest number is the pattern to drill.

Trap	What it does	In this drill	Your misses
Dropped element	Leaves out a required term or step.	4	
Wrong stem number	A figure copied from the prompt that is not the answer.	2	
Adjacent category	The right idea in the wrong bucket.	10	
Inverted operation	Direction flipped: add/subtract, cause/effect, higher/lower.	7	
Absolute language	Always, never, guarantee — where judgment applies.	3	
Confusion set	Every option is real; the test is exact role-matching.	7	
Camouflage	Answers a stem fact that was never the question.	3	

Anchor rows — the concept list

One row per concept: the rule to lock in, the trap that catches people, and the tell in the question that signals it.

#	Concept	Rule	Trap	Tell
1	The Simple View of Reading	Reading comprehension = decoding × language comprehension; if either is zero, comprehension is zero.	Adding the two parts, or assuming strong oral language makes up for weak decoding.	A reader strong in one component and weak in the other.
2	Scarborough's Reading Rope	Word-recognition strands (phonological awareness, decoding, sight recognition) become increasingly automatic; language-comprehension strands (background knowledge, vocabulary, language structures, verbal reasoning, literacy knowledge) become increasingly strategic.	Placing vocabulary or background knowledge in word recognition.	"Which strand of the rope...?"
3	Phonological awareness vs. phonics	Phonological awareness is oral work with sounds and needs no print; phonics links sounds to letters.	Calling any sound-related activity with letters "phonemic awareness."	Whether letters or print are present in the task.
4	Orthographic mapping and Ehri's phases	Words become instantly recognized "sight words" by bonding their spellings to their pronunciations; readers move from pre-alphabetic to partial, full, then consolidated alphabetic phases.	Believing sight words are learned by memorizing word shapes.	A child's reading or spelling behavior matched to a phase.
5	Syllable types	A closed syllable ends in a consonant and has a short vowel; an open syllable ends in a vowel and has a long vowel; vowel-consonant-e makes the vowel long.	Assuming any vowel next to a consonant is short.	A word split into syllables with a vowel-sound question.
6	Morphology in word analysis	Morphemes — prefixes, roots, and suffixes — are the smallest units of meaning and help readers decode and spell longer words.	Counting syllables when asked for morphemes.	"How many morphemes...?" or a long word with affixes.
7	Components of fluency	Fluency is accuracy, automaticity (rate), and prosody together, in service of comprehension.	Equating fluency with reading fast.	A reader who is fast but flat, or accurate but slow.
8	Evaluating beginning-reading resources	Resources for beginners should match the phonics taught (decodable text) and teach sounding out, not guessing from pictures or context.	Choosing predictable or leveled books that train three-cueing guessing.	A resource that tells children to look at the picture or guess what makes sense.

Course scope (public description): Elementary Literacy Curriculum is a comprehensive course that deepens an educator's knowledge of language acquisition and progressively complex concepts and skills surrounding literacy. This course explores critical elements of the science of reading and writing, including applying key theories and

research used to support the development of literacy, evaluating diverse resources, and utilizing purposeful oral, written, and digital communication in elementary curriculum. Candidates delve into the foundational aspects of literacy, including phonological awareness, phonics, word analysis, fluency, and comprehension, while also gaining insights into how these elements shape and influence literacy development. This dynamic course empowers educators to create a solid foundation for students' literacy skills and a lifelong love of reading and writing within diverse learning environments.